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THE BUBBLY DUCK

Mrs. Dubovsky smoothed the starched, flowery house dress over her ample bosom and lifted the window that faced her neighbor's home across the alley.

"Yoo hoo, Mrs. Siegel", she shrieked in a Molly Goldberg fashion. My mother responded by wiping her perpetually busy hands on her apron and slid up her window. "What is it Mrs. Dubovsky?" she inquired.

"So I heard that Estelle is going to take piano lessons from a regular teacher. When will she start, and how much will it cost you?"

"I just this minute called Miss Gershwin. How did you hear about it so fast?" said my mother incredulously.

Mrs. Du, as we referred to her somewhat affectionately, giggled and confessed, "Your bedroom window was open a little bit. So how much will you pay?"

"She's asking fifty cents for the hour, but before you tell me that's too much, she promises to have my Estelle play in a recital in six months!"

"My Shayndie is almost ten, six months older than your daughter and hates the idea of lessons. How will you make Estelle practice?"

"She wants to do it very badly and promises to practice every day.
Enough Mrs. Dubovsky, my blintzes are calling me."

Miss Gershwin arrived the next day at five P.M. I learned later that her real name was Miss Gershowitz, but Gershwin had a tremendous impact on music-loving families. She was tall and extremely thin. Her nostrils dilated as she inhaled the delicious chicken soup aroma that permeated the rooms. My mother immediately offered her a glass of tea, which was accepted with gratitude. As extreme

slenderness was a pain in the heart of a good Jewish mother, my instructor was also given a thick chunk of rye bread with lots of sweet butter. This was demolished in record time. I then sat next to my new acquaintance on the shiny piano bench, and Miss Gershwin showed me my first book and explained the notes on the keyboard. In the book, she wrote and identified every note, and showed me how to curl my fingers and lift my wrists. By the end of the hour, I played a simple nursery rhyme with one uplifted hand, and felt extremely proud. Miss Gershwin then glued a gold star in the back of the book and said, "If you practice every day, you will learn a new song each week. When you do a good job, like you did today, you will get a gold star. When you earn ten gold stars, I will bring you a surprise."

I was so excited and my family loved to hear me practice. The songs were memorized because it was faster than reading the written-in notes. Time flew by and soon there were ten shiny stars in my book.

Miss Gershwin wiped the last crumb of buttered rye bread from her slender face and gave me a wrapped package. Inside was a little Donald Duck that smelled wonderful. It was soap that bubbled and floated in the bathtub. What a wonderful present!

The pieces became classical and before long, I was playing, "To a Wild Rose" and "March Militaire" It was necessary for me to memorize everything because I hadn't been taught to read the notes.

One day, my piano teacher gave my mother a formal program to the recital I would participate in. There was my name and the two selections I would play printed in beautiful letters on the roster. This glorious event would take place in a special building in down town Brooklyn. We invited the neighbors, several friends and many relatives. My mother bought me a new navy blue, silky dress with black patten leather shoes. I convinced her to put on taps after the recital because dancing and acrobatics were next on the agenda.

Although I remember that my hands were sweaty and slid on the Steinway note keys, I didn't make any mistakes and it was a complete success. We all had a sumptuous Chinese dinner afterwards.

My piano career continued for several years and I accumulated many gold stars and interesting gifts from my teacher who never seemed to put on a pound. My mother was puzzled and felt challenged. She even added honey to the buttered bread, and gave Miss Gershwin pieces of chicken and jars of soup to take home.

Mrs. Dubovsky came up with her solution to Miss Gershwin's dilemma "What she needs, Mrs. Siegel, is a pleasant man to make her happy. When a woman is happy, she gets nice and fat." Mr. Dubovsky obviously made his entire family very happy.

With all her faults, Miss Gershwin kindled the spark of my love of beautiful music. When I occasionally play, "To a Wild Rose", I can almost smell the surprisingly sweet fragrance of the bubbly duck that floated.

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